

B-PLAN Sunil Bansal, BJP national general secretary

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that it has been unable to furnish a strong response to such aggression from the Trinamool administration.

That's where someone like Bansal—cast in the mould of the classic RSS apparatchik—comes in. A pracharak is a key figure for the RSS, one who connects the ground to the big picture, alive to the minutiae at the hyperlocal level and harnessing those in the service of ideology. As a pracharak loaned to the BJP, Bansal brings those qualities into the game. His first task in Bengal is to ensure district- and taluka-level leaders call out police high-handedness. That will vivify and hold the ground while helping to build a larger narrative.

Put together, Bengal, Odisha and Telangana account for 80 Lok Sabha seats. In 2019, the BJP won only 30 of these, so the potential for growth is obvious. In all three states, the party is up against formidable regional parties with high aspirations. Of late, the BJP has virtually hijacked the status of the main opposition in all three states, but is struggling to step up the aggression. Telangana is due for assembly polls next year, and the BJP faces complex three-cornered contests in many constituencies. The ruling Telangana Rashtra Samithi under K. Chandrashekar Rao will be playing on home turf, from where it's showing signs of sallying out with national ambitions. The Congress is in the third corner—but no pushover still. In Odisha, where Naveen Patnaik's BJD continues to be a formidable player, the BJP has not exactly forced its friend-cum-enemy out of his comfort zone. But it's Bengal that's crucial for the BJP—despite 2019 marking a triumphant entry, it won only 18 of its 42 seats. And more than political acreage, the BJP considers Bengal an ideological battleground.

Bansal is seen as the man for the job because he has exhibited many of the requisite skills in Uttar Pradesh. During his nearly decade-long tenure in the state, after being deputed there from the ABVP in 2013, Bansal was credited with building the organisation from the ground up. Along with Amit Shah, then in-charge of UP, he secured anew the loyalties of old leaders who had strayed, while engineering defections in rival parties. His method was not to seek one-sided loyalty. He ensured district-level leaders with potential reached the legislative council. After the party's 2017 victory, he ensured that 18,000-odd state unit workers got appointed on several offices of profits across the country: 108 of them are independent directors on PSUs and other government institutions.

SUNIL BANSAL WILL OVERSEE BJP'S PREP FOR 2024 IN WEST BENGAL, ODISHA AND TELANGANA

These organisational skills, built around a selection process that backed quality, paid dividends as factionalism ebbed. Electorally, the BJP became a formidable force, registering sweeping victories in two general elections and assembly polls each. If the totemic figure of Narendra Modi loomed over the airwaves, and later Yogi Adityanath became a state-level icon of the same ilk, much of the earth connect came via the quiet work Bansal put in for Shah.

In mid-August, as the BJP elevated him from the position of general secretary (organisation) in UP, it was clear Bansal was being trusted to repeat the execution of these skills in three greenfield states. If the shift was preceded by a slightly conflictual relationship with CM Yogi, it was balanced by the value placed on him—in the BJP's history, he's only the second person to be rewarded thus. The first was Modi, who was similarly elevated from the Gujarat unit in 1998.

As he takes on three frontline states now, Bansal will be assisted by general secretary D. Purandeswari and Vijaypal Tomar in Odisha—the idea here is to build pro-Modi sentiments around central projects and social sector schemes. In Bengal, Mangal Pandey, former cabinet minister from Bihar, has replaced Kailash Vijayvargiya as in-charge, while Arvind Menon was shifted to Telangana to team with general secretary Tarun Chugh. Bansal joined duties there in August-end, as state unit chief Bandi Sanjay Kumar was trying to whip up some fervour with a walkathon. Here, the challenge for the BJP is to build up a rural presence, and identify talent before poll season. Bansal's erstwhile colleague in the ABVP, Revanth Reddy, now the Congress state chief, is aggressively taking on the TRS as well. The ABVP is traditionally strong on key campuses in the state but many of its alumni have gone over to the TRS, TDP and Congress over the years. With Bansal around, efforts to win some of them back may accelerate. ■